



UPA'S BALLOT BOUNTY

- Public spending of Rs 25,000 crore to revive the agriculture sector.
- Upward revision of the MSP of wheat from Rs 850 to Rs 1,000 per quintal.
- Soft loans of Rs 2,000 crore for sugar mills and a Rs 420-crore subsidy for sugar exports.
- New government-funded schools, colleges, universities and vocational schools.
- Scholarship schemes and government funding for meritorious students from minority communities, literacy drives in minority-populated areas and madarsa modernisation.
- Extension of the National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme from 330 districts to all 600 districts of the country.
- Raising of the bonus ceiling for organised labour from the current minimum of Rs 2,500 per month to Rs 3,500.
- Pension scheme for BPL senior citizens and a health insurance scheme for the poor.
- Aam Aadmi Bima Yojna, which will bring landless households in the unorganised sector under the insurance safety net.
- 13 new railway projects with a total investment of over Rs 2,500 crore.

VOTE BAIT: Prime Minister Manmohan Singh (right) with Finance Minister P. Chidambaram

Day this year that the prime minister woke up to it, announcing a public spending of Rs 25,000 crore to revive the ailing sector. When members of the Bharatiya Kisan Union met Manmohan in early September, he assured them that farmers' livelihood and food security would be taken care of. Later last month, he promised the AICC general secretaries that as per their demand, the UPA Government's flagship project—the National Rural Employment Guarantee scheme—which now covers 330 districts, would be extended to all 600 districts of the country. The programme envisages providing employment to at least one member of every poor family for a minimum of 100 days in a year. Its extension to the entire country was no doubt a laudable move. But what was left unsaid was that the announcement had come at the behest of the new Congress General Secretary Rahul Gandhi, which

also perhaps explains why no questions were asked about the additional expenditure—up from Rs 8,800 crore to Rs 22,000 crore. Rural Development Minister Raghuvansh Prasad Singh, however, admitted, "Rahul's keen interest in the scheme has certainly made my job easier." Again, in the last week of September, Manmohan announced a one-time ex-gratia payment of Rs 3 lakh to the next of kin of each fisherman held captive in Pakistan. He also promised a sum of Rs 30,000 to owners of smaller fishing boats and Rs 5 lakh to those of trawlers seized by Pakistan, all from the Prime Minister's National Relief Fund.

If Manmohan was on an announcement spree, his Cabinet colleagues weren't far behind. Finance Minister P. Chidambaram addressed a public rally in Shimla, where he announced the Aam Aadmi Bima Yojna in a bid to bring landless households in the unorganised sector under the insurance safety net. With an overwhelming majority of the